

Installing AE MCP Bridge: instructions for an AI agent

You are installing AE MCP Bridge for the user: an MCP server (Node.js, no dependencies) plus a panel inside Adobe After Effects. Work through the steps in order. Every step ends with a **Done when** check: run it and reach it before moving on. Steps marked **HUMAN** are actions only the user can perform; ask for them in plain words, wait for the user's confirmation, then run the check yourself. Talk to the user in their language.

The human manual with background and troubleshooting: [MANUAL.pdf](#).

`<bridge>` below means the installation folder, `<node>` the full path printed by step 2.

1. Agree on the plan

Ask the user, in one message:

- Installation folder. Default: `C:\MCP\ae-mcp` on Windows, `~/MCP/ae-mcp` on macOS. It must be local, outside OneDrive / Google Drive / Dropbox / iCloud.
- Which clients to connect: Claude Code (for one project folder, or for all sessions), Claude Desktop with Cowork, Codex.
- Whether to install the optional Claude skill `after-effects-motion`.

Done when you have the folder and the list of clients.

2. Node.js

Run `node --version` (and `where node` on Windows or `which node` on macOS to get `<node>`).

- Version 18.17 or newer: continue.
- Missing or older: **HUMAN** installs the LTS version from <https://nodejs.org>, then reopens the terminal.

Done when `node --version` prints v18.17 or newer.

3. Get the files

If `<bridge>/src/mcp-server.mjs` already exists, use that folder. Otherwise clone the repository into `<bridge>` (`git clone https://github.com/justajazz/ae-mcp-bridge.git <bridge>`) or unpack the ZIP the user gives you.

Then run the offline self-test inside `<bridge>` :

```
npm test
```

Done when it ends with `fail 0`. No `npm install` is needed: the bridge has no dependencies.

4. After Effects preference

HUMAN: in After Effects open **Edit > Preferences > Scripting & Expressions** (macOS: *After Effects > Settings > Scripting & Expressions*), enable **Allow Scripts to Write Files and Access Network**, click OK.

Done when the user confirms.

5. Install the panel

```
node <bridge>/src/install-panel.mjs --link
```

It finds every installed After Effects and writes a small loader into its `ScriptUI Panels` folder. Writing into Program Files triggers a Windows UAC prompt: tell the user beforehand that it will appear and that they should confirm it (**HUMAN**). On macOS run it as `sudo "$(which node)" <bridge>/src/install-panel.mjs --link` (the full Node path keeps it working when Node comes from nvm or Homebrew; the user types the password, **HUMAN**).

Done when the output ends with `done` for each After Effects version. If After Effects is not found, ask the user for its folder and pass `--ae "<folder>"`.

6. Start the bridge

HUMAN: restart After Effects, open **Window > ae-mcp-panel.jsx**, dock the panel, click **Start bridge**, tick **Start automatically when this panel opens**.

Then verify the whole chain yourself:

```
node <bridge>/scripts/check-install.mjs
```

Done when it prints `RESULT: connected`. If it prints *never started in this bridge folder*, the panel is not running yet or uses another bridge folder: ask the user what the panel's status line says.

7. Connect the clients

Do only the clients chosen in step 1.

- **Claude Code, one project folder** (recommended to start): in that folder run `claude mcp add --scope project after-effects -- node "<bridge>/src/mcp-server.mjs"`. **HUMAN:** the next time `claude` starts in that folder, choose **Use this MCP server**.
- **Claude Code, all sessions:** `claude mcp add --scope user after-effects -- node "<bridge>/src/mcp-server.mjs"`. Tell the user the trade-off: the tool descriptions load into every session and After Effects is reachable from any project (every call still asks permission unless allowed).
- **Claude Desktop and Cowork:** `node <bridge>/scripts/configure-client.mjs claude-desktop`. **HUMAN:** quit Claude Desktop completely (tray / menu bar icon > Quit) and start it again. Cowork uses the same connectors.
- **Codex:** `node <bridge>/scripts/configure-client.mjs codex` (registers the server as `ae_mcp_bridge`). If the script reports another `after_effects` server (the original "After Effects MCP by Ruslan Tsapenko"), **HUMAN** turns it off in Codex Settings > MCP and stops its panel: both offer tools with the same names. **HUMAN:**

restart Codex completely.

The script backs the config file up, adds only the `after-effects` entry and leaves an existing entry untouched.

Done when each chosen client is configured: `claude mcp get after-effects` lists the server for Claude Code; the script printed `added` or `already configured` for Claude Desktop and Codex.

8. Optional: the Claude skill

If the user wants it, copy `<bridge>/skills/after-effects-motion` to `~/.claude/skills/after-effects-motion` (Windows: `%USERPROFILE%\.claude\skills\after-effects-motion`). For Claude Desktop / Cowork the user uploads the zipped folder in **Settings > Capabilities > Skills (HUMAN)**.

Done when the folder is in place, or the user declined.

9. Hand over

Tell the user:

- what was installed and where (`<bridge>` , the panel, the bridge folder `C:\MCP\ae-bridge`);
- which clients are configured and which restarts or approvals are still theirs;
- the first request to try after restarting the client: *"Check the connection to After Effects. Don't change anything."*;
- that every tool call is one Ctrl+Z, and the project is backed up to `C:\MCP\ae-bridge\backups` before the first change.

Done when the user has this summary. Keep their After Effects projects untouched throughout: the installation never opens, saves or edits a project.